area like the valley cannot be 'azaad' in a meaningful way. It would be a state always at the mercy of others. And if the neighbours choose to block the roads and cut off the valley, you would be on your knees. Kashmir does not produce everything the people need. Your needs will, therefore, have to be met by imports from outside of Kashmir. We must draw the lessons from what is happening in the rest of the world. Europe is witnessing the emergence of the European Union, wherein all countries of that region have got together for a brighter future for their citizens. Boundaries are hardly visible, enemies have become friends, and the economic power of that block of countries is growing.

They (the jehadis) are using you; your children are the sacrificial goats! I am very moved when I see youthful lives snuffed out so needlessly. The lifeless bodies of young, handsome and innocent lads whose faces reminded me of my son and made me feel sorry for these poor Kashmiri boys. They were armed to the teeth and carrying the AK-47 – the death warrant, as I would call it. Does any country allow people carrying weapons to infiltrate across their borders? Did you give birth to them to die in this manner? Where are the children of the 'tanzeem' (jehadi organizations) leaders? Getting degrees and higher education in Bombay, Bangalore or abroad! How many of them have died for this 'cause'? Who are the people making palatial houses all over Kashmir, and where is the money coming from? Please ask these questions to the 'khalifas' or the leaders of the 'tanzeems' when we finish our operation and go away. (Recently, much noise was created when Asiya Andrabi, the head of a belligerent Kashmiri women's organization named 'Dukhtaran-e-Millat', wanted her son to go to Malaysia for higher studies – I had advised the Kashmiris to beware of such leaders twenty years ago!)

Meanwhile, one of my officers would hand over to me my AK-47, which I never failed to carry. At the same time, much to everyone's astonishment, a soldier would fix a small target with the picture of a 'skull and crossed bones' on the nearest tree. I would then load the rifle in a swift motion, and ask someone sitting in the audience as to which part of the target I should aim at. The bullet would be out with a loud bang before I received the response to my question. I seldom missed the centre of the target. I would fire a few more shots at the target. This had a spellbinding effect on the audience. At times, the womenfolk would come running towards the congregation thinking of the worst.

I then made the point that as a brigade commander, it was not my job to shoot, but to make plans and evolve the strategy. Yet if I could still hit the bullseye, my men could shoot through a coin. Therefore, what chance did novices like their son or brother have against the well-trained soldiers of the Indian Army? It would be an unequal fight.